TEST STITCH CHECKLIST

Two minutes before the real garment. Read the sample, run the checks, and know whether the problem is your setup or the file.

Problems that move around live on your side. Problems that repeat in the exact same spot live in the file.

READ YOUR TEST STITCH FIRST

- ☐ **Where** did it go wrong? One small area points at the file. All over points at setup: backing, hooping, tension, needle.
- ☐ **When** did it go wrong? Bad from stitch one is usually hooping, backing, or a dull needle. Trouble at the same spot every run is usually in the file.
- ☐ **Same on a second test?** File problems repeat in the same place. Machine problems wander.

THE SWAP TEST

Run a design you trust, one that has stitched clean before, on today's exact setup: same fabric, same backing, same needle. It stitches clean, your setup is fine and the problem is in the new file. It fails the same way, the file is innocent.

THREAD BREAKS, CHECK IN ORDER

1. **Needle.** Good for 8 to 10 hours of stitching, then it is dull. Swap it before anything else.
2. **Thread path.** Look for a snag, or a guide it jumped out of.
3. **Speed.** Drop to about 600 SPM and watch what is actually happening.
4. **Tension, last.** Half steps, test stitch between changes, one change at a time.

BEFORE YOU RUN THE REAL GARMENT

- ☐ Fresh needle, right type for the fabric. The cheapest fix in embroidery, and the most skipped.
- ☐ Backing matched to the fabric: cutaway for knits, stretch, and anything washed hard.
- ☐ Firm hoop, garment not stretched. Stretch it hooping and it relaxes later and takes the design with it.
- ☐ Speed set for the fabric, slower on caps, fleece, and dense fills.
- ☐ Test stitch the actual design on the closest scrap to the real fabric, every new file.
- ☐ Smallest lettering checked against the floor: plain block under about 5 mm tall starts losing the openings inside letters on most fabrics. Script needs close to double.
- ☐ Look at any very dense spot and the outlines on the test piece before production.

WHEN IT IS BIRDNESTING

Almost never the file. Rethread with the presser foot up so the thread seats in the tension discs, check the take-up lever, check the bobbin direction and tail, and hold the thread tail for the first stitches.

WHEN IT IS THE FILE: THE MESSAGE TO SEND YOUR DIGITIZER

Hi, I test stitched the design at **[finished size]** on **[fabric]** with **[backing]**, **[needle type and size]**, running at **[speed]**. What I am seeing: **[puckering through the filled areas / the small lettering filled in / gaps along the outline on one side / thread breaks at the same spot every run]**. Photo of the sewout attached. A design I run often stitches clean on this same setup, so I believe this one is in the file. Can you review **[the density in the filled areas / the lettering size / the pull compensation]**? The smallest lettering is **[height in mm]** tall. Happy to send the test piece if it helps. Thanks.

Send evidence, not frustration: a photo and three facts, fabric, size, what you saw. That is the version digitizers answer fast.